

Taking the Capitol steps to success

Virginia Capitol Semester

The Wilder School Virginia Capitol Semester program continues its signature internship opportunity for students to gain hands-on public service experiences directly within the office of a Virginia General Assembly House delegate or State senator. With the state capitol just down the streets from the Monroe Park campus, Capitol Semester interns orbit the seat of government covering key areas of influence across the Commonwealth.

These talented students strengthen their understanding of the legislative processes in action. Taking on integral responsibilities, they examine policy issues as well as collaborate directly with legislators and their constituents. These real-world governmental experiences develop the critical skills for students to move toward career success.

This year, the Capitol Semester program recorded its largest cohort of more than 50 students.

The unique hands-on experience facilitates a pipeline for networking and permanent employment in state government, and many Wilder School alumni have springboarded careers in public service as a direct result of their work.

What students are saying

Honors student Catherine Boynton is strengthening her career and focusing on government sectors she previously had not known.

“(This internship) has inspired me to focus more on state level policy work and analysis rather than federal level. Where I had previously looked at public policies with a nationally focused lens, I am now more inspired to focus on the impact of federal and state policies on individual states.” - Catherine Boynton, Political Science

With law school ambitions, Samuel Orr is uncovering new skills and embracing opportunities to prepare for his next steps after college, thanks to the responsibilities he’s taken on.

“I spent a lot of my time working with my Chief of Staff on preparing speeches that my Delegate gave, and writing and suggesting productive edits for our weekly newsletters, so on top of school, it’s really helped me hone down a professional and well-rounded writing style, something that’s extremely important in the legal field.” - Samuel Orr, Homeland Security and Emergency Preparedness

Sunshine Tomlin continues to develop rich, personal connections as well as mentorship and guidance to support her path to join law-making.

“The connections I made throughout the program were able to set me up for success in other parts of my career and future opportunities as well. I was able to talk with many people who had a similar career path as mine and I was able to get advice on what options I could explore next later on in my life.” - Sunshine Tomlin, Criminal Justice